decompose it. Composting is one of the best method of waste disposal as it can turn unsafe organic products into safe compost. On the other side, it is a slow process and takes lot of space.

Vermicomposting

Vermicasting, also called vermicomposting, is the processing of organic wastes through earthworms (Figure 1). It is a natural, odourless, aerobic process, much different from traditional composting. Earthworms ingest waste then excrete casts – dark, odourless, nutrient- and organically rich, soil mud granules that make an excellent soil conditioner. Earthworm casts are a ready-to-use fertilizer that can be used at a higher rate of application than compost, since nutrients are released at rates that growing plants prefer.



Vermicasting can be done on a small scale by homeowners with household organic wastes, on a large-scale by farmers with manure or by the food industry using organic wastes such as fruit and vegetable cull materials. Through proper design, vermicasting is a method of waste handling that:

- is clean, socially acceptable, with little to no odour.
- requires no energy input for aeration.
- reduces the mass of waste by 30%.
- produces a valuable vermicast byproduct.
- even generates worms as fishing bait.



Recovery and Recycling

Recycling is the process of converting waste products into new products to prevent energy usage and consumption of fresh raw materials. Material for recycling may be collected separately from general waste using bins and collection vehicles, a procedure called kerbside collection. In some communities, the owner of the waste is required to separate the materials into different bins (e.g. for paper, plastics, metals) prior to its collection. In other communities, all recyclable materials are placed in a single bin for collection, and the sorting is handled later at a central facility. The latter method is known as "single-stream recycling.

The most common products recycled include aluminium such as beverage cans, copper such as wire, steel from food and aerosol cans, old steel furnishings or equipment, rubber tyres, polyethylene and

XII Std - Home Science EM_Unit 8.indd 207 23-03-2020 3.32.56 PM